

Figure 2.8 Feeding the Silkworm

Spinning Silk Thread from Cocoon

The cocoons (Figure 2.9) are put in hot water, so that the gum on the outer shell is removed. After that, using a stick the loose fibres are slowly unreeled.



Figure 2.9 Silk Cocoon

2.3.2 Silk Filament Reeling

It is passed through an eyelet and reeled on to a wheel. The fibres are moved from left to right hand slowly and rolled up. This process is called reeling. Three to ten fibres are combined to make a suitable silk filament.

Throwing

The reeled silk is known as raw silk. The process of transferring silk fibre to yarn is known as throwing. This is sorted based upon size, colour, length or quantity. The raw silk skeins are soaked in warm water with soap or oil. This softens the sericin and helps in the movement of the threads. The skeins are placed on light reels and the silk is wound on the bobbins after mechanical drying. When the strands are wound, desired amount of twist can be given. If two or more yarns are wound it is called doubling. Based on the requirements the twist may be given in the same or opposite direction. In order to make yarns into fabrics, the yarns are dyed first. The yarns are washed with soap water to remove sericin. This process is called degumming. The silk filaments are reeled into skeins. This is packed into small bundles called books, which is kept ready for marketing.

Weighing of Silk

The silk fabric manufactures buy silk yarns in kilograms for cloth production. During degumming process the silk weight is lost. In order to increase the weight of silk which was lost in degumming the silk yarns are treated with chemical and metals. This process increases the weight of fabric and is called weighting of silk. This processes increase the weight of the silk but the natural elasticity is lost.

The silk also gets deteriorated on exposure to sunlight, perspiration and dry cleaning.

2.3.3 Characteristics of the Silk Fibre

Shape	Like glass rod
Length	30,000 – 39,000 cm
Elasticity	More
Stretch ability	More
Flexibility	Medium

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